

MISSION BRIEF / CONSUMER DIVISION

# BETTER-FOR-YOU INDULGENCE

An orbital market map of guilt-free food & beverage  
UNITED STATES + AUSTRALIA · 6 NEED-STATE GALAXIES · 30 COMPANIES

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Companion to the interactive space map (<output/index.html>)

# A note before the numbers

I'm Arjun Kulshrestha, and I want to work in consumer venture. Not because consumer is the glamorous end of VC — it usually isn't — but because consumer outcomes are decided by operating skill and taste in a way no other category is. The cap table doesn't save you in the snack aisle. Velocity does. This memo and its companion interactive map are my attempt to show, rather than claim, how I think about a category.

## Why this category

I chose better-for-you indulgence — what consumers honestly call **guilt-free food** — because it sits at the intersection of the two biggest forces reshaping food: **premiumisation** and **health becoming a lifestyle aesthetic rather than a sacrifice**. It also produced the most instructive exits in recent consumer memory (Poppi, Siete, LesserEvil, SmartSweets) while still being early in my second market, Australia. And it is ruthlessly founder-dependent: every breakout on my map traces to an operator with unusual taste in product, brand, or distribution. That's the kind of investing I want to learn.

## What I believe (opinions, not consensus)

1. Taste parity is a ticket, not a thesis. The moat is repeat purchase plus something structural: David bought its ingredient supplier; LesserEvil owned its manufacturing; Feastables owns its audience. 'It's healthy AND delicious' is table stakes.
2. The diet aisle is dead; the permission aisle replaced it. Winners sell in the candy aisle, the chemist, the canteen — never next to meal shakes. Placement IS positioning.
3. GLP-1 is a re-rating event, not a demand shock. Fewer eating occasions means each snack must justify itself — protein, fibre, portion logic. That advantages exactly this map.
4. Australia is a 2–3 year time machine with structural cheats: Chemist Warehouse as a health-channel beachhead, a grocery duopoly that makes national distribution one deal, and school canteen policy that legislates kids' BFY demand.
5. The best operators in this category increasingly don't need venture (Chomps ~\$900M revenue, near-bootstrapped; FUNDAY, Denada, Macro Mike all self-funded to national shelf). Sourcing here means earning allocation, not just finding deals.
6. Celebrity is distribution, not brand. Feastables works because the audience is the channel; most talent-led launches confuse reach with repeat. I'd underwrite the repeat-purchase curve, never the launch week.
7. Claims risk is the category's quiet killer. Poppi paid a class-action settlement on its way to a \$1.95B exit. The next generation must formulate to survive scrutiny, not just to pass a TikTok taste test.

# Indulgence isn't dying. It's being re-priced.

**Why now.** Health flipped from restriction to status. Protein, gut health and 'no added sugar' are how mainstream shoppers — not dieters — now buy treats. Roughly 1 in 8 US adults is on a GLP-1 (AlixPartners / Food Institute reporting), compressing snacking occasions 40–60% while spend shifts to protein (+65%) and fibre-forward foods. Every remaining indulgence occasion must now earn its place. That is a formulation and brand problem incumbents are structurally bad at.

**The proof.** PepsiCo paid **\$1.95B for Poppi** (2025) off ~\$500M sales. **OLIPOP** reached **\$1.85B, profitably**. Hershey paid ~\$750M for **LesserEvil**; PepsiCo **\$1.2B for Siete** (2024). **David** did ~\$100M first-year revenue and raised at **\$725M**. This is no longer niche CPG — it's the most reliable strategic M&A lane in food.

**Why incumbents are vulnerable.** Their core brands carry zero health permission (Coke can't sell you gut health), reformulating flagship products indicts the portfolio, and their innovation cycles run in years while challengers iterate in weeks. Their rational move is to buy — which is exactly what they're doing, at 3–4x revenue.

**Why startups win.** Founder taste compounds: product taste (David's macro maths), brand taste (BelliWelli made IBS funny), and distribution taste (Feastables skipped DTC for Walmart; FUNDAY launched in pharmacies). Speed plus permission plus owned audiences beats shelf-buying budgets early.

**Venture-scale vs. niche CPG.** The line is need-state ownership. Venture outcomes happen when a brand owns a sentence in the consumer's head ('soda that's good for me', 'candy without sugar') and rides it across formats and channels. Niche outcomes happen when a brand owns a SKU. I'd underwrite: repeat rate >40%, gross margin >40% with a path to 50, velocity that survives the end of launch promo, and a founder who can hire a supply chain before it breaks.

## THE ONE-LINE THESIS

Back founder-operators who give consumers **permission to enjoy** — with taste parity as the entry fee, repeat purchase as the scoreboard, and supply-chain or audience ownership as the moat. Overweight Australia, where the US playbook re-runs with structural shortcuts and half the competition.

# What counts as better-for-you indulgence

Food and beverage whose **job is pleasure** — treats, snacks, desserts, comfort food, soda — engineered and branded so the consumer feels **healthier, more values-aligned, or less regretful** choosing it. The product must win a blind taste test against the 'bad' original, or it isn't in the category; it's diet food.

**In:** zero-sugar candy and chocolate, dessert-coded protein, prebiotic soda, gut-friendly and allergen-free treats, clean-label comfort food (ramen, mac & cheese, chips), kids' lunchbox-compliant treats, portion-logic snacking for GLP-1 appetites.

**Out:** meal replacements and medical nutrition (function without joy), supplements, raw 'whole foods' (an apple needs no permission), legacy diet brands (the consumer's job there is restriction, not pleasure), and alcohol alternatives (adjacent, different drivers).

## The language shift

| 1990s–2000s DIET ERA                         | 2020s PERMISSION ERA                                                |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 'Low fat', 'lite', 'guilt' framing           | '28g protein', 'no added sugar', '150 calories' — specs, not shame  |
| Aspartame apologetics                        | Allulose, monk fruit, prebiotic fibre — sweeteners as features      |
| Diet aisle ghetto                            | Candy aisle, chemist, canteen, c-store — placed beside the original |
| Target: dieters (mostly women, mostly guilt) | Target: everyone — fitness, GLP-1, parents, 'healthy hedonists'     |
| Taste sacrifice accepted                     | Taste parity mandatory; health is the tiebreak, not the pitch       |

Sourcing note: thesis shaped by trade press (Food Dive, FoodNavigator, NOSH), funding databases (Crunchbase, Tracxn, PitchBook), founder interviews, and consumer-investing media — e.g. The Consumer Ascent (Substack, channel-check research on emerging brands), The Consumer VC, and Express Checkout / The Curious Consumer podcast. Full source links sit inside each company dossier in the interactive map and in the appendix.

## Seven buyers, one need: permission

| SEGMENT                                    | MOTIVATION                                                                 | PAIN                                                         | WTP                                 | CHANNEL                                   | MESSAGE THAT LANDS                                                             |
|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Protein-first (post-gym-bro)</b>        | Macros as daily budget; protein = default heuristic                        | Supplement aesthetics; chalky textures                       | High (\$2.50–4.50/bar)              | C-store, grocery, DTC subs                | 'Candy-grade taste, athlete-grade specs' — David, Magic Spoon, Vitawerx        |
| <b>GLP-1 / appetite-conscious</b>          | Fewer occasions; each bite must justify itself; muscle preservation, fibre | Big portions; food waste; nausea triggers                    | High, low volume — premium per-unit | Pharmacy, grocery, DTC                    | 'Portion logic + density: 'small, complete, worth it'                          |
| <b>Parents &amp; lunchbox buyers</b>       | Rules (school policy, sugar caps) decide; kids must actually eat it        | Kid taste-veto; label policing; price-per-box maths          | Medium-high, repeat-heavy           | Grocery, Costco, chemist (AU)             | 'Treats you say yes to' — Twisted Healthy Treats, Blue Dinosaur, Sweet Loren's |
| <b>Gen Z wellness</b>                      | Health as identity content; gut health > calories; brand as social object  | Scepticism of legacy claims; broke-but-premium               | Medium; trial-happy, fickle         | TikTok-to-Target, c-store                 | Humour + aesthetics + one hero claim — Poppi, BelliWelli, Bobby                |
| <b>Busy professionals</b>                  | Convenient upgrade of existing habits (ramen, coffee, dessert)             | Time; decision fatigue; office snack drawer guilt            | High; subscription-friendly         | DTC, Amazon, premium grocery              | 'Your 3pm fix, fixed' — immi, Goodles, Remedy                                  |
| <b>Dietary-restricted households</b>       | Safety first (allergens, FODMAP, diabetes); whole family converts          | Exclusion from normal treats; cross-contamination trust      | Highest WTP, lowest churn           | Specialty + mainstream grocery, pharmacy  | Certification + 'eat like everyone else' — Fodbods, Sweet Loren's, Noshu       |
| <b>Healthy hedonists / premium grocers</b> | Indulgence without compromise as a values statement; ingredient literacy   | Greenwashing fatigue; premium price needs premium experience | Highest basket; taste-led           | Whole Foods / premium indies, hospitality | Provenance + design + zero apology — StrangeLove, Mid-Day Squares, Mingle      |

The premiumisation thread: across every segment, consumers are trading fewer, better occasions — paying 2–4x the legacy price for a snack that carries identity. The losing position is the middle: not cheap, not credible.

## Six elements, organised by need-state

I deliberately mapped need-states, not product aisles — consumers don't shop 'low-sugar confectionery', they shop 'I refuse to give up sweets'. In the interactive map each need-state is a living element — Fire (protein), Crystal (sugar-free), Water (drinks), Flora (gut), Terra (comfort), Wind (culture & kids) — and each is a clickable system; planets are companies, sized by scale signal, ringed when acquired (kept as pricing comps), pulsing when breaking out.

| ELEMENT / NEED-STATE                                                                                                 | WHY CONSUMERS CARE                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | REPRESENTATIVE                                                            | MATURITY                     | VC                      | KEY RISKS                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Fire — Protein as Pleasure</b><br><i>"I want a treat that earns its place in my day."</i>                         | Protein has replaced 'low fat' as the universal health heuristic. The winning brands code as candy, cereal and popcorn — not gym supplements — which unlocks mass grocery and convenience channels.                                                | David, Chomps, Magic Spoon, Khloud, Macro Mike, Vitawerx, Chief Nutrition | Scaling                      | High                    | Formulation arms race; novel-ingredient scrutiny (e.g. EPG); celebrity-brand noise; incumbents (Quest, Barebells) own shelf space. |
| <b>Crystal — Sweet, Without the Sugar</b><br><i>"I refuse to give up sweets — take out the sugar, not the joy."</i>  | Sugar is the single most avoided ingredient in both the US and Australia. The unlock was taste parity plus fun branding — these brands sell in the candy aisle and at the chemist, not the diet aisle.                                             | FUNDAY Natural Sweets, SmartSweets, Noshu, Mid-Day Squares, Denada        | Scaling -> Crowded (gummies) | Medium-High             | Sweetener fatigue (sugar alcohols, stevia aftertaste); private label moves fast; single-hero-SKU concentration.                    |
| <b>Water — Functional Refreshment</b><br><i>"I want the ritual of a Coke without drinking a Coke."</i>               | The category that proved BFY indulgence is venture-scale: Poppi exited to PepsiCo for \$1.95B and OLIPOP was last valued at \$1.85B. Australia is running the same playbook 2–3 years behind the US.                                               | OLIPOP, Poppi, Remedy Drinks, Naked Life, Nexba, Bobby, StrangeLove       | Crowded (US) / Scaling (AU)  | Medium (US) / High (AU) | US shelf is saturated post-Poppi; flavour/format copycats; big-soda response (Coke Simply Pop); probiotic claims litigation.       |
| <b>Flora — Gut Health &amp; Free-From</b><br><i>"I want to eat like everyone else without paying for it later."</i>  | Gut health is the fastest-growing wellness claim, and GLP-1 users need fibre and digestive support. Free-from brands win fierce loyalty because the alternative for these consumers is exclusion, not another brand.                               | BelliWelli, Fodbods, Sweet Loren's                                        | Emerging                     | High                    | Niche-to-mass leap is hard; medical-adjacent claims invite regulator attention; low-FODMAP is a small beachhead.                   |
| <b>Terra — Clean-Label Comfort</b><br><i>"I want childhood comfort food I don't have to hide in my pantry."</i>      | Nostalgia is the cheapest customer acquisition there is. Upgrading an existing habit (ramen, mac & cheese, popcorn) beats inventing a new one — and acquirers agree: Siete went for \$1.2B, LesserEvil for ~\$750M.                                | Goodles, immi, Mingle, Siete Foods, LesserEvil                            | Scaling                      | High                    | Premium price vs. \$1 incumbent comparison; velocity pressure in mainstream grocery; 'clean label' is unregulated language.        |
| <b>Wind — Culture-Led &amp; Kids' Treats</b><br><i>"I buy the story (or my kids' lunchbox rules decide for me)."</i> | Distribution is the moat — creators bring their own. Feastables hit \$250M revenue in under three years off MrBeast's audience. Meanwhile parents are an underserved, rule-driven buyer (school policies, sugar limits) with high repeat purchase. | Feastables, Twisted Healthy Treats, Blue Dinosaur                         | Emerging                     | Medium                  | Key-person risk on creator brands; kids' marketing regulation; novelty purchase vs. true repeat.                                   |

# The physics of the category

**Taste vs. health.** Non-negotiable: lose the blind taste test, lose the repeat. Every dossier on my map starts with whether taste parity is real (David, FUNDAY) or marketing (most of the long tail).

**Trust & ingredient credibility.** One viral 'actually it's full of seed oils / sugar alcohols' moment can kill a brand. SmartSweets' gut-distress complaints opened the door FUNDAY walked through with no sugar alcohols.

**DTC vs. retail.** DTC is a lab, not a business: CAC inflation killed DTC-only food. The modern arc is DTC for data -> retail for scale (David, Magic Spoon) — or skip DTC entirely when you own an audience (Feastables -> Walmart).

**Repeat & basket.** Habit formats (soda, ramen, pantry staples, lunchbox) structurally beat novelty formats (gifting chocolate). The basket question: does it enter the weekly shop or the occasional treat run?

**Gross margin & supply chain.** BFY ingredients (allulose, EPG, grass-fed, allergen-free lines) cost more; target 40%+ now, 50% at scale. The biggest outcomes internalised supply: David bought Epogee; LesserEvil self-manufactures.

**Retail & private label.** Slotting fees, promo cadence and velocity reviews are existential; Coles/Woolworths private label moves faster than US chains. Differentiation must survive a knockoff at 60% of price.

**Incumbent response.** Buy, not build — Soulboost died, then Pepsi bought Poppi. Strategic appetite is the exit floor; it's also a ceiling on how long a window stays open before the acquired brand gets the incumbent's distribution.

**Regulatory / claims.** FDA scrutiny of 'healthy' labelling, prebiotic/probiotic claims litigation (Poppi's settlement), FSANZ novel-ingredient approvals in AU (EPG isn't approved there yet — a real expansion gate for David-style formulations).

# Ten places I'd go hunting

## W01 — GLP-1-native snacking

**The gap:** Compressed appetites need dense, small, complete bites — nobody owns the format yet. **Playbook:** US first, AU as fast-follow; pharmacy + grocery. **Traction I'd look for:** Repeat rate among medicated users; pharmacy velocity; RD/clinician endorsements.

## W02 — Australia's healthy soda window

**The gap:** Poppi/OLIPOP playbook is 2–3 yrs behind in AU; Remedy proved scale, nobody owns 'fun'. **Playbook:** Brand-led launch via c-store + duopoly grocery; Bobby is the early contender. **Traction I'd look for:** C-store reorder rates; Gen Z social pull; duopoly ranging review survival.

## W03 — Sugar-free chocolate that's actually good

**The gap:** Gummies are solved (FUNDAY, SmartSweets); chocolate taste parity isn't. **Playbook:** Premium gifting + everyday block; chemist channel in AU. **Traction I'd look for:** Blind taste wins vs. Lindt; repeat >40%; margin >45%.

## W04 — Kids' canteen-compliant treats at scale

**The gap:** AU school traffic-light policy legislates demand; fragmented supply. **Playbook:** B2B2C canteen lists + grocery; export the compliance playbook to US schools. **Traction I'd look for:** Canteen list penetration; parent repeat; school-term seasonality survival.

## W05 — Allergen-free indulgence platform

**The gap:** Whole households convert on one member's allergy; US has Sweet Loren's, AU has no leader. **Playbook:** Mainstream grocery freezer/chiller, not health aisle. **Traction I'd look for:** Household (not individual) retention; certification moat; cross-format expansion.

## W06 — High-fibre as the next protein

**The gap:** GLP-1 constipation + gut-health wave; fibre is where protein was in 2015. **Playbook:** Snack formats with 8–10g fibre that taste indulgent; grocery + TikTok education. **Traction I'd look for:** Claim comprehension in ads; repeat after first GI experience (dose matters).

## W07 — Protein frozen desserts done right

**The gap:** Halo Top proved demand then taste-collapsed; tech (allulose, EPG-style fats) has moved. **Playbook:** Grocery freezer; AU first via Denada-style distribution then US. **Traction I'd look for:** Velocity vs. Ben & Jerry's adjacency; second-purchase rate; cold-chain margin.

## W08 — Clean-label Asian comfort formats

**The gap:** immi proved ramen; dumplings, bao, instant noodles in AU (high Asian-Australian population) untouched. **Playbook:** DTC trial -> Asian grocers -> mainstream; founder authenticity essential. **Traction I'd look for:** Community organic pull; non-Asian crossover; freezer economics.

## W09 — Functional coffee & 3pm energy

**The gap:** The afternoon treat occasion (coffee + biscuit) has no BFY owner; beforeyouspeak-style AU brands sub-scale. **Playbook:** Office channel + grocery pods + c-store RTD. **Traction I'd look for:** Workplace reorder; RTD margin; caffeine-claims hygiene.

## W10 — Trust infrastructure / 'verified label' brands

**The gap:** Claims-risk era rewards brands built on radical transparency (batch testing, open COAs). **Playbook:** DTC-first with retail halo; possibly the platform play across categories. **Traction I'd look for:** Willingness to pay for verification; press/regulator goodwill; licensing interest.

## The skeptical read

**Overhyped where?** US functional soda (post-Poppi, the strategics have shopped), protein bars (David's heat is pulling in undifferentiated me-toos), and anything whose pitch deck leads with 'the GLP-1 opportunity' instead of a product.

**Too crowded** Low-sugar gummies, US prebiotic beverages, generic 'clean' protein powders, keto legacy formats. In each, shelf is allocated, CAC is bid up, and differentiation is a flavour, not a moat.

**Retention is the lie most often told** Novelty velocity masquerades as product-market fit. Celebrity and creator brands are most exposed: launch-week sellouts say nothing about week 26. The only honest metrics are second-purchase rate and post-promo velocity.

**Undifferentiated branding** Half the category is the same brand: pastel can, lowercase wordmark, 'finally, X without the bad stuff'. When the design language is a commodity, the brand isn't doing any work — price and shelf position decide.

**Claims that won't survive** Prebiotic doses below clinical relevance, 'gut health' on products with 2g of fibre, 'natural' sweetener halos. Poppi settled a class action; FDA 'healthy' rules and FSANZ approvals will catch the sloppy.

**What caps venture outcomes** Food brands rarely become platforms; most are single-need-state businesses sold at 2–4x revenue. If the entry price assumes software multiples, even a \$750M exit can return badly. And the best operators (Chomps) may simply never sell you equity.

## How I'd evaluate a deal here

**Founder-market fit.** Has the founder personally lived the need-state, and shipped product before? (Rahal/RXBAR -> David is the archetype.)

**Product velocity.** Time from insight to shelf; SKU iteration cadence; kill-rate honesty.

**Repeat purchase.** >40% repeat, rising cohort curves, subscription or weekly-basket entry.

**Gross margin.** >40% now, structural path to 50%+ (supply ownership, scale pricing).

**Retail velocity.** Units/store/week vs. category norms after promo ends; reorder breadth.

**Community & organic demand.** Searches, UGC, and waitlists the brand didn't pay for; earned distribution (FUNDAY's pharmacy pull, BelliWelli's virality).

**Channel expansion logic.** Each new channel adds margin or audience, not just volume; AU->US or US->AU plan that respects regulatory gates.

**Category creation.** Does the brand own a sentence? ('soda that's good for you') — that's what strategics pay 4x revenue for.

**Acquirer map.** PepsiCo, Hershey, Mondelez, Nestlé, Unilever in the US; in AU, also the path of US strategics buying their ANZ beachhead.

# Companies I'd want to meet, and what I'd ask

## The shortlist

**FUNDAY (AU)** — the most exportable AU brand on the map; I want to understand the US pharmacy/grocery entry maths and whether they'll finally take external capital.

**Bobby (AU)** — the live test of whether the Poppi playbook re-runs in Australia before the window closes.

**Noshu (AU)** — first external raise after A\$4M to A\$38M in four years inside the duopoly — rare growth-stage entry in AU BFY.

**BelliWelli (US)** — the cleanest community-wedge-to-retail story; I want the cohort curves behind the virality.

**immi (US)** — the highest-frequency habit format on the map; if repeat holds, this compounds quietly.

**Chief Nutrition (AU)** — small, profitable, community-funded — exactly the kind of operator AU venture overlooks.

**David (US)** — not because I could win the allocation, but because every question I have about supply-chain moats in food runs through Epogee.

## Questions I'd ask founders

- What's your second-purchase rate, and what was it before you knew I'd ask?
- Show me velocity in your oldest 50 doors after the launch promo ended.
- Which ingredient or claim in your product would survive a hostile lab test going viral?
- What do you control in your supply chain that a copycat with \$5M can't buy in 12 months?
- If your biggest retailer launches a private-label version at 60% of your price, what happens to you?
- Who is the acquirer, what sentence do you own in their strategy deck, and why can't they build it?
- What did you taste-test and kill last quarter?

## What this project taught me

Three things changed my mind while building this. First, I started believing distribution stories beat product stories — then David's Epogee acquisition and LesserEvil's self-manufacturing convinced me the deepest moats here are upstream, not downstream. Second, Australia isn't a smaller US: the chemist channel, the duopoly, and canteen policy create different winning playbooks, which is precisely why a 50/50 US-AU lens finds mispriced deals. Third, the hardest discipline in consumer is ignoring launch heat — every embarrassing outcome in this category was visible early in one number, the second-purchase rate. I'd rather be the analyst who asks for that number than the one who forwards the TikTok.

# Company database — 30 planets

Status: IND independent / BRK breakout / EXIT acquired (kept as pricing comps). Facts are flagged verified / company-reported / estimate inside each signal. Full dossiers and clickable sources live in the interactive map.

| COMPANY                                          | GEO | ELEMENT                           | CORE PRODUCT                                                            | FUNDING / SCALE SIGNAL                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------|-----|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Siete Foods</b> <small>EXIT</small>           | US  | Terra / Clean-Label Comfort       | Grain-free tortillas, chips, salsas and Mexican-American heritage foods | Acquired by PepsiCo for \$1.2B (announced 2024) — verified                                                                 |
| <b>LesserEvil</b> <small>EXIT</small>            | US  | Terra / Clean-Label Comfort       | Organic popcorn, puffs and 'Space Balls' snacks (coconut-oil popped)    | Acquired by Hershey, ~\$750M reported (closed Nov 2025) — verified deal, price per WSJ report                              |
| <b>Goodles</b> <small>IND</small>                | US  | Terra / Clean-Label Comfort       | Protein- and veggie-boosted boxed mac & cheese and noodles              | \$19.4M raised (\$13M Series A, Sep 2023, L Catterton) — verified                                                          |
| <b>immi</b> <small>IND</small>                   | US  | Terra / Clean-Label Comfort       | High-protein, low-carb instant ramen                                    | ~\$29M raised over 4 rounds; latest round Dec 2024 (Tracxn) — verified                                                     |
| <b>Mingle</b> <small>IND</small>                 | AU  | Terra / Clean-Label Comfort       | Natural, low-sugar seasonings, sauces and gravies                       | National Woolworths + Coles ranging; early accelerator funding only (PitchBook/Crunchbase) — verified distribution         |
| <b>Feastables</b> <small>IND</small>             | US  | Wind / Culture-Led & Kids' Treats | Chocolate bars with simplified ingredient lists                         | ~\$250M 2024 revenue, ~\$20M profit; ~\$520M projected 2025 (reported) — credible third-party reporting, not audited       |
| <b>Twisted Healthy Treats</b> <small>IND</small> | AU  | Wind / Culture-Led & Kids' Treats | Lower-sugar, hidden-veg kids' frozen treats and ice creams              | AU grocery + canteen distribution — company-reported, unverified scale                                                     |
| <b>Blue Dinosaur</b> <small>IND</small>          | AU  | Wind / Culture-Led & Kids' Treats | Paleo-style real-food bars and kids' lunchbox snacks                    | National AU grocery distribution — company-reported, unverified scale                                                      |
| <b>OLIPOP</b> <small>BRK</small>                 | US  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | Prebiotic soda with classic flavours (Vintage Cola, Root Beer)          | \$50M raise at \$1.85B valuation (Feb 2025); \$400M+ 2024 sales; profitable — verified                                     |
| <b>Poppi</b> <small>EXIT</small>                 | US  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | Prebiotic soda (apple-cider-vinegar origin story)                       | Acquired by PepsiCo for \$1.95B (Mar 2025); ~\$500M 2024 sales — verified                                                  |
| <b>Remedy Drinks</b> <small>BRK</small>          | AU  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | Live-cultured kombucha, prebiotic Sodaly, ACV switchel, shots           | ~A\$162.7M FY2025 revenue (IBISWorld); Series B from L Catterton & Kin Group (2023) — verified                             |
| <b>Naked Life</b> <small>IND</small>             | AU  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | 100% natural sugar-free sodas and non-alcoholic cocktails/spirits       | Stocked nationally in Woolworths, Coles, IGA, Dan Murphy's; founded 2016 — company-reported                                |
| <b>Nexba</b> <small>IND</small>                  | AU  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | Sugar-free, naturally sweetened sodas, kombucha and gut-health drinks   | Founded 2010; national distribution; Product of the Year 2017 — company-reported                                           |
| <b>StrangeLove</b> <small>IND</small>            | AU  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | Premium craft sodas, tonics and lo-cal mixers                           | Established premium distribution in AU hospitality and grocery — company-reported, unverified scale                        |
| <b>Bobby</b> <small>IND</small>                  | AU  | Water / Functional Refreshment    | Better-for-you cola and soft drinks (sugar-free, prebiotic)             | Early-stage; expanding AU distribution — company-reported, unverified scale                                                |
| <b>Sweet Loren's</b> <small>IND</small>          | US  | Flora / Gut Health & Free-From    | Allergen-free, gluten-free refrigerated cookie dough and pastry         | National US grocery distribution; largely founder-controlled — company-reported                                            |
| <b>BelliWelli</b> <small>IND</small>             | US  | Flora / Gut Health & Free-From    | Gut-friendly, low-FODMAP snack bars and gut-health products             | \$10M Series B (Oct 2024); ~\$26M total raised — verified                                                                  |
| <b>Fodbods</b> <small>IND</small>                | AU  | Flora / Gut Health & Free-From    | Low-FODMAP, gut-friendly snack bars and protein bars                    | Seed funding from Scale Investors (AU angel network) — verified investor, undisclosed amount                               |
| <b>David</b> <small>BRK</small>                  | US  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure        | 28g-protein, 0g-sugar, 150-calorie bars (and expanding formats)         | \$75M Series A (May 2025) led by Greenoaks with Valor; \$725M valuation; ~\$100M first-year revenue — verified             |
| <b>Chomps</b> <small>IND</small>                 | US  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure        | Grass-fed beef, venison and turkey meat sticks                          | Est. ~\$900M 2025 revenue (Forbes estimate); \$100M credit line with Wells Fargo (Apr 2025) — estimate + verified facility |

| COMPANY                          | GEO | ELEMENT                            | CORE PRODUCT                                                          | FUNDING / SCALE SIGNAL                                                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------|-----|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Magic Spoon</b> IND           | US  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure         | High-protein, zero-sugar 'childhood' cereal and treats                | ~\$209M total funding across 5 rounds (Tracxn); \$85M round in 2022 alongside Target launch — verified                                                                                            |
| <b>Macro Mike</b> IND            | AU  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure         | Plant-based protein powders, baking mixes and peanut-butter treats    | Self-funded; 35+ staff (Business News Australia) — company-reported                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Khlood</b> IND                | US  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure         | Protein popcorn (7g protein per serve)                                | \$12M oversubscribed round (Apr 2025); Serena Ventures, WME, Shrug, K5 — verified                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Vitawerx</b> IND              | AU  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure         | Protein-coated chocolate, wafers and choc-coated nuts                 | Founded 2015; nationally distributed in AU health retail; no disclosed external funding — company-reported                                                                                        |
| <b>Chief Nutrition</b> IND       | AU  | Fire / Protein as Pleasure         | Grass-fed collagen protein bars, biltong and collagen powders         | ~A\$4M annual revenue run-rate, profitable, revenue doubled YoY (Equitise raise materials) — company-reported                                                                                     |
| <b>SmartSweets</b> EXIT          | NA  | Crystal / Sweet, Without the Sugar | Low-sugar gummies and candy                                           | Majority stake sold to TPG Growth at \$360M (Oct 2020) — verified                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Noshu</b> IND                 | AU  | Crystal / Sweet, Without the Sugar | Sugar-free donuts, baking mixes, frostings and chocolate ('Snackles') | ~A\$38M expected sales; first external raise underway; projecting 2.5x in 3 years (SmartCompany / company) — company-reported                                                                     |
| <b>FUNDAY Natural Sweets</b> IND | AU  | Crystal / Sweet, Without the Sugar | No-added-sugar, prebiotic-fibre gummies and chocolate                 | Bootstrapped at launch (founder stated no external funding plans, 2022); national Chemist Warehouse + grocery distribution; US site live — verified distribution, funding status company-reported |
| <b>Mid-Day Squares</b> IND       | NA  | Crystal / Sweet, Without the Sugar | Functional chocolate squares (protein + fibre, low sugar)             | ~\$16.5M raised over 3 rounds (Tracxn/Crunchbase) — verified                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Denada</b> IND                | AU  | Crystal / Sweet, Without the Sugar | Sugar-free ice cream                                                  | 1,250+ AU stores within 3 years, no outside investment at launch; now exporting — company-reported                                                                                                |

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